

05 — Temporal Workflows

Audience: engineers adding or debugging a business process; anyone asked "why is this approval stuck?" **Companion docs:** [04 Running flows](#) · [03 Module interaction](#) · [13 Operations](#) **Code:**

`services/workflows/app/` — `workflows.py` (the processes), `activities.py` (every Register call), `api.py` (the orchestrator HTTP front), `worker.py`, `codec.py`, `types.py`

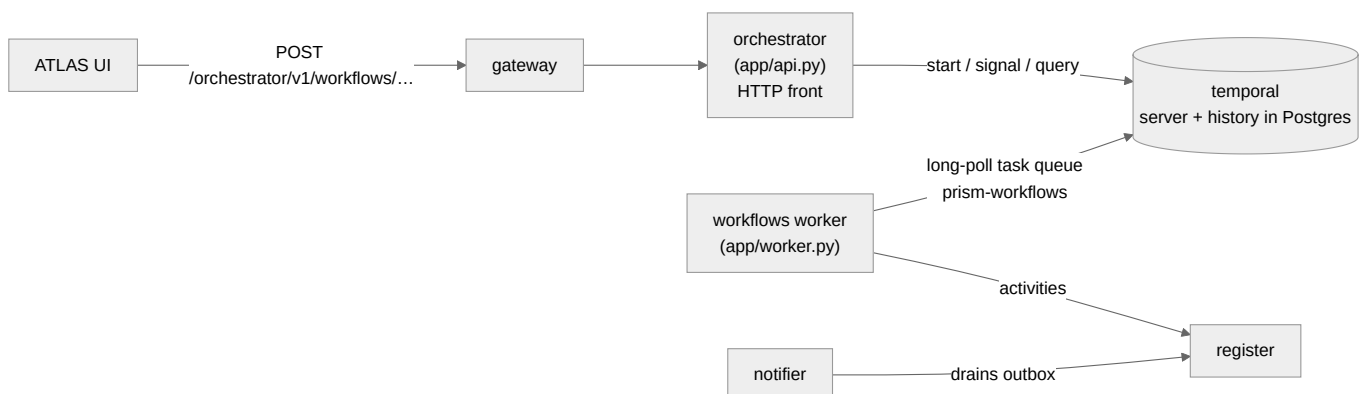
1. Why Temporal is here at all

A lead conversion is: read the lead → wait, possibly for **days**, for a human decision → create an entity, a deal and one or more product lines → mark the lead converted → file evidence. If that runs as a chain of HTTP calls and the process dies after step 3, you have a deal with no lines and a lead that still says "open". Nobody knows. There is no retry.

Temporal makes the *process itself* durable. The workflow's state survives a worker restart, a redeploy, and a five-day wait for a Credit Committee. A failed step is retried with backoff; a step that cannot be retried triggers explicit compensation.

The rule this creates: any multi-step change with a human decision point, or with more than one write that must not be left half-done, belongs in `workflows.py` — not in a FastAPI route.

2. The moving parts



Component	Process	Responsibility
orchestrator	<code>python -m app.api</code>	HTTP: start workflows, deliver signals, answer queries. Verifies the caller. Never contains business logic.
worker	<code>python -m app.worker</code>	Long-polls the <code>prism-workflows</code> task queue and <i>executes</i> workflow and activity code.
temporal	container	Durable event history, timers, task queues. Stores state in its own Postgres databases.
notifier	container	Drains the Register's notification outbox to email.

If the worker is stopped, nothing errors — everything silently stalls. Workflow starts still get accepted (202) and sit in the queue. This is the single most common "the approval disappeared" cause. Check `docker compose ps workflows` first.

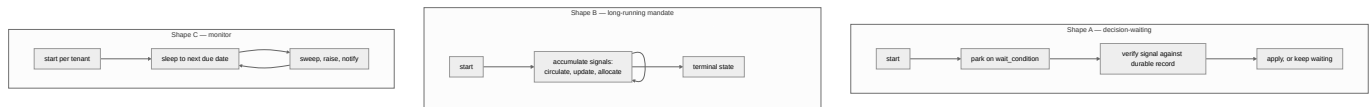
Task queue: `prism-workflows` (`WORKFLOWS_TASK_QUEUE`). Namespace: `default` .

3. The workflow catalogue

Fourteen workflows are registered on the worker.

Workflow	Started by	Waits for	What it produces
<code>IngestInteractionWorkflow</code>	reference/demo	—	The minimal example. Read this one first.
<code>VoxTouchpointWorkflow</code>	VocX capture	(optionally) company confirmation / lead selection	Entity + lead + interaction from a field touchpoint
<code>LeadConversionWorkflow</code>	"Push to Deals"	human approve/reject	Entity → deal → product lines, lead marked converted
<code>LeadQualificationWorkflow</code>	ATLAS	qualification review	The first, cheapest gate — no deal work begins on an unqualified lead
<code>DealStructuringWorkflow</code>	ATLAS	Credit Committee decision	A lending facility structured to the sanction milestone
<code>SyndicationMandateWorkflow</code>	ATLAS	IM circulation, lender responses, allocation	The syndication mandate's whole journey
<code>AssetMonetisationWorkflow</code>	ATLAS	teaser circulation, buyer updates, NDA, offers	The AM mandate's journey to Closed or Lost
<code>DocumentCollectionWorkflow</code>	ATLAS	each document received	Evidence that the mandatory documentation set is complete
<code>CpcsChecklistWorkflow</code>	ATLAS	checker approval	The authoritative CP/CS checklist (maker-checker)
<code>AdvayaHandoffWorkflow</code>	ATLAS	second-person approval	An immutable handover package to the loan-management system
<code>SanctionExpiryMonitorWorkflow</code>	on sanction	timers	The clock on a perishable sanction validity window
<code>DocumentExpiryMonitorWorkflow</code>	per tenant	timers	Tenant-wide document-expiry sweep
<code>CovenantMonitorWorkflow</code>	per tenant	timers	Tenant-wide covenant clock (generation, overdue, waiver expiry)
<code>EwsCaseWorkflow</code>	on EWS case	timers, SLA	One early-warning case's clock, auto-escalating on a lapsed SLA

Three shapes recur:



4. The two ideas that make this trustworthy

4.1 A signal is untrusted until verified against a durable record

This is the pattern to internalise. A Temporal signal can, in principle, be delivered by anyone who can reach the Temporal server. So **the signal is only a nudge; the authority is a row in the Register.**

```
# activities.py – verify_decision
"""Validate a lead-conversion approve/reject signal BEFORE the workflow lets it count ...
Fail-closed against a DIRECT Temporal signal – for BOTH approve and reject.
```

```
The single-winner decision resource is the SOLE authority. The worker always derives the
outcome, the approver identity AND the note from the persisted record – NEVER from the
signal's (latest-caller) token or note."""
```

Consequences that matter operationally:

- **Two approvers, same outcome** → the run and the database name the same (first) approver and note. No race on who "won".
- **A spoofed or premature signal is discarded and the run keeps waiting** — it can neither finalise a fake rejection nor deny service to a pending approval.
- **A transient Register failure raises rather than returning "invalid"**, so Temporal retries *without consuming the decision*. Distinguishing a genuine `NotFound` from a 502 is the whole point.

The same pattern governs **run control** (cancel / return-for-information / resubmit) via `verify_control`, and committee, syndication, AM and facility decisions via their own `verify_*` activities.

In dev (`WORKFLOWS_INTERNAL_SIGNING_SECRET` empty) verification is bypassed and the signal is trusted — which is exactly why that variable must be set in production.

4.2 The worker re-mints the human's identity

By default a worker's writes would land as its own service key. Instead:

```
# config.py
internal_signing_secret: str = ""
# "When set, the worker RE-MINTS a short-lived signed context from the caller identity
# carried in the workflow input, so the Register authorizes writes as the HUMAN (with
# their scope) – not the worker's service key."
```

So a SCOPED user's workflow cannot write rows that user could not write directly. The workflow is not an authority escalation.

5. Retry policy — two tiers, deliberately

```
services/workflows/app/workflows.py:
```

```

_RETRY = RetryPolicy(
    # _IO – ordinary reads/writes
    initial_interval=timedelta(seconds=1),
    backoff_coefficient=2.0,
    maximum_interval=timedelta(seconds=30),
    non_retryable_error_types=_DETERMINISTIC,
    # 8 attempts ≈ a 90-second window (1+2+4+8+16+30+30), enough to ride out a DB restart
    # or connection-pool flush; 5 gave up after ~15s, which turned every brief Register
    # blip into a dead run. All _IO activities are idempotency-keyed, so the extra
    # attempts are replay-safe.
)

_DURABLE = RetryPolicy(
    # _DURABLE_IO – writes that MUST land
    initial_interval=timedelta(seconds=1),
    backoff_coefficient=2.0,
    maximum_interval=timedelta(minutes=5),
    non_retryable_error_types=_DETERMINISTIC,
    maximum_attempts=0,
    # unlimited – reconcile until the write lands
)

```

"'Unbounded' means unbounded for OUTAGES, not for refusals. A 422/404/403/409 is the Register's final answer and will read the same on attempt 10,000, so it must break the loop rather than be reconciled against."

This is the distinction to preserve when you add an activity: **a refusal is deterministic and must be non-retryable; an outage is transient and must be retried**. Getting it backwards either spins forever on a validation error or gives up on a DB restart.

6. SLA, reminders and escalation

Every decision-waiting workflow shares `_Foundation`:

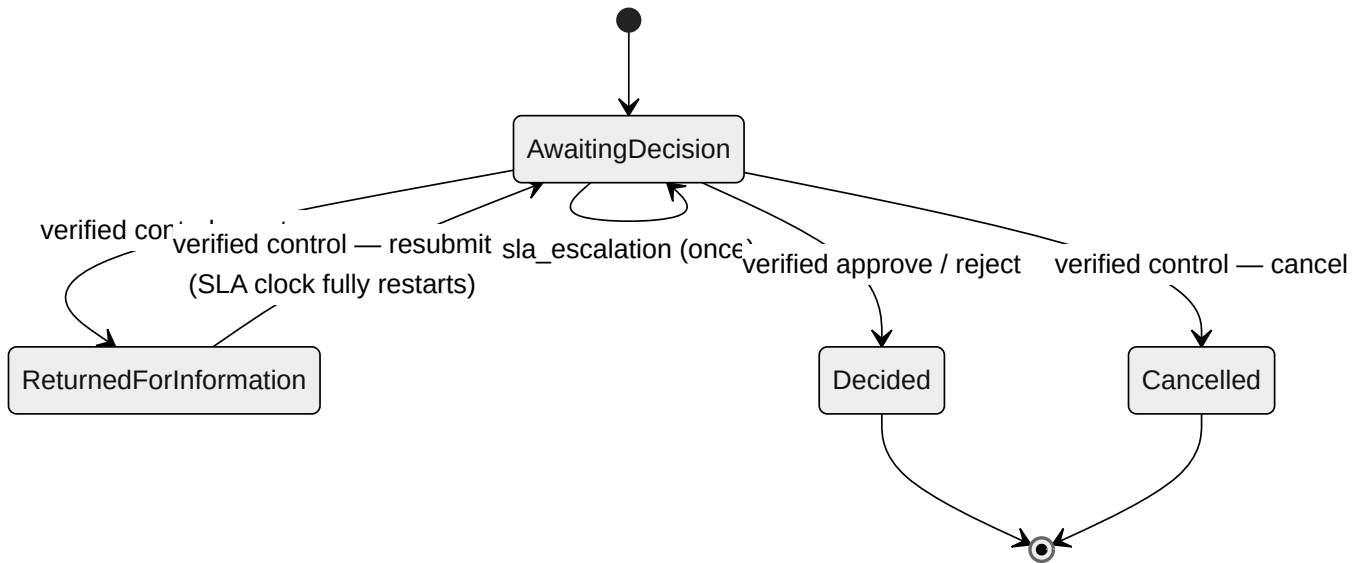
```

class _Foundation:
    """The shared run-control + SLA state machine for a decision-waiting workflow.

    * controls          – the UNTRUSTED queue of (action, control_ref) signals
    * business_status    – AwaitingDecision / ReturnedForInformation / Cancelled / ...
    * SLA bookkeeping    – reminder count + escalation flag; the clock RESETS on resubmit.
    """

```

The wait loop sleeps until **whichever comes first**: the decision deadline, the next SLA reminder, or the escalation point (`next_wakeup`). Escalation outranks a reminder (`due_sla_event`).



A resubmit resets `start`, `reminders_sent` and `escalated` — the decision window restarts *fully*, which is the honest behaviour when new information has been supplied.

Very long waits

```
if workflow.info().is_continue_as_new_suggested():
    workflow.continue_as_new(dataclasses.replace(
        inp, resumed_elapsed_hours=waited.total_seconds() / 3600))
```

When the event history grows too large, the run continues as new — carrying the elapsed window across the reset so the SLA clock is not silently rewound.

7. Payload encryption

Workflow inputs, activity arguments and results all live in Temporal's history, **outside** the Register's PostgreSQL and its row-level security. With `WORKFLOWS_PAYLOAD_ENCRYPTION_KEY` set, every payload is encrypted client-side (worker *and* orchestrator) with AES-256-GCM before it reaches the Temporal server.

	Without the key	With the key
Temporal history	plaintext business data	ciphertext
Temporal Web UI	readable payloads	opaque blobs (unless a codec server is configured)
Posture	dev	production

Key format: base64url, exactly 32 bytes decoded. Rotation is supported via a 4-byte key-id prefix — pass previous keys as `retired` so old history still decodes.

8. The orchestrator HTTP surface

`services/workflows/app/api.py`. Reached through the gateway at `/orchestrator/...`.

Starting a workflow

```
POST /v1/workflows/vox-touchpoints      → 202
POST /v1/workflows/lead-conversions     → 202
POST /v1/workflows/lead-qualifications  → 202
POST /v1/workflows/deal-structurings    → 202
POST /v1/workflows/document-collections → 202
POST /v1/workflows/syndications         → 202
POST /v1/workflows/asset-monetisations  → 202
POST /v1/workflows/cpcs-checklists      → 202
POST /v1/workflows/advaya-handover      → 202
POST /v1/workflows/ews-cases            → 202
```

Delivering a decision

```
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/approve
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/reject
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/committee-decision
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/syndication-decision
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/am-decision
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/control          (cancel / return / resubmit)
POST /v1/workflows/advaya-handover/{lending_id}/approve|reject|return
POST /v1/workflows/cpcs-checklists/{id}/approve|reject|return
POST /v1/workflows/cam-reports/{id}/approve|reject|return
```

Feeding a long-running mandate

```
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/circulate-im      POST /v1/workflows/{id}/circulate-teaser
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/lender-update     POST /v1/workflows/{id}/buyer-update
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/allocate          POST /v1/workflows/{id}/record-nda
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/revise-credit-note POST /v1/workflows/{id}/record-offer
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/document-received
POST /v1/workflows/{id}/confirm-company   POST /v1/workflows/{id}/select-lead
```

Reading state

```
GET /v1/workflows      list runs
GET /v1/workflows/{id} one run (queries the workflow)
GET /v1/workflows/pending everything awaiting a human – the approval queue
GET /v1/workflows/actions which actions this user may take
```

`GET /v1/workflows/pending` is what the ATLAS "Today" approval queue reads. The parked run *is* the work item — there is no separate task table to drift out of sync.

Authorization on this surface

Two independent checks:

1. **At the gateway** — `routes_map.py` maps each start/decision route to the RBAC operation the resulting change requires, so an unauthorised user is stopped *before* a durable workflow starts.
2. **At the orchestrator** — it re-checks fresh committee / handover authority against Access before it persists or signals. Defence in depth; the Advaya handover and CP/CS approval both do this because they authorise money movement.

9. Adding a workflow — the checklist

- ☐ Define the input/result dataclasses in `app/types.py`.
- ☐ Write the workflow in `app/workflows.py`; inherit `_Foundation` if it waits for a human.
- ☐ Every side effect goes through an `@activity.defn` in `app/activities.py` — **never** call the Register from workflow code directly.
- ☐ Choose `_IO` (bounded) or `_DURABLE_IO` (unbounded) per activity, and make sure a *refusal* is in `_DETERMINISTIC`.
- ☐ Every write activity takes an `idempotency_key`. Retries are guaranteed, so replay-safety is not optional.
- ☐ Register the class in `app/worker.py`'s import list **and** the `Worker(...)` construction.
- ☐ Add the start / signal routes to `app/api.py`.
- ☐ Add those routes to `services/gateway/app/routes_map.py` with the operation they exercise.
- ☐ Add any new Register capability to `svc_workflows` in `evam_backend_core/service_policy.py`.
- ☐ If a human decides something, persist a **durable decision record** and verify signals against it. Do not trust the signal.

10. Debugging

Symptom	First checks
"I approved it and nothing happened"	Is the worker running? <code>docker compose ps workflows</code> . Then: was a durable decision record written? An unverified signal is <i>silently discarded by design</i> .
Workflow start returns 202 but nothing runs	Worker down, or listening on a different task queue than the orchestrator started on.
Activity retrying forever	It is on <code>_DURABLE_IO</code> and the Register is returning a <i>refusal</i> that is not in <code>_DETERMINISTIC</code> . Fix the classification.
Temporal UI shows opaque payloads	Expected — <code>WORKFLOWS_PAYLOAD_ENCRYPTION_KEY</code> is set. Not a fault.
Run vanished after days	It hit <code>continue_as_new</code> ; look for the newer run id with the same workflow id.

Temporal Web UI: `docker compose --profile debug up -d temporal-ui`, then `http://localhost:8088`. It is profile-gated because it is a read window into every payload — bring it up to investigate, take it down afterwards.

Worker metrics: set `WORKFLOWS_METRICS_BIND_ADDRESS` to expose a Prometheus endpoint with task/activity latencies, failures and slot usage.